The Group Mural

Civic Skill: Cooperation | EYLF: EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 2 (Community) | Duration: 20–30 minutes | Age: 4–6 years

LEARNING INTENTION

Children will contribute to a shared creative work under a simple but strict rule — you cannot cover or erase anyone else's contribution — building the experience of holding space for others within a shared enterprise.

SUCCESS CRITERIA

- I can add to a shared artwork without taking over.
- I can see my contribution as part of something bigger than itself.
- I can appreciate someone else's contribution, even if it's different from what I would have made.

MATERIALS

- One large sheet of paper or fabric (at least 1m x 2m) spread on the floor or mounted on a wall
- A shared theme determined together in advance (e.g., 'Our Community,' 'The World We're Growing,' 'All the Feelings')
- Paints, markers, collage materials — in shared palettes, not individual sets
- One rule card displayed visibly: 'YOU CANNOT COVER SOMEONE ELSE'S WORK'

ACTIVITY STEPS

1. RULE INTRODUCTION (3 min): Read the one rule aloud. 'This is the only rule. Everything else is up to you. But this one rule is serious — why do you think it might matter?' Take responses. Let children articulate the principle themselves.

2. PLANNING CIRCLE (5 min): Brief discussion as a group: 'What's our theme? What might you add? Where might you add it?' Not everyone needs a plan — some children will know what they want to do when they see the space.

3. MURAL TIME (15 min): Children work simultaneously. Educator circulates, narrating positively: 'Look — Zara added a sun here. And now Tom is adding clouds near it — he saw what Zara did and responded to it.' Point out moments of visual cooperation as they emerge.

4. CLOSING LOOK (5 min): Step back together. 'Can you find what you made? Can you find something you love that someone else made? This whole thing — every part of it — came from us, all of us, together.'

EXTENSIONS

- Make it permanent: use fabric paint and have it professionally finished as a class banner
- Repeat the mural at the end of the program — compare the two: 'How have we changed? What do we know now that we didn't?'
- Invite families to view the mural and ask children to be guides: 'Let me show you what I made and what I love that someone else made'

ASSESSMENT

- Observe: Does the child seek out space that doesn't overlap others, or do they need support to notice others' work?
- Note moments of spontaneous positive response to peers' contributions
- The mural is itself an assessment artefact — photograph with individual annotations

EDUCATOR REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Were there moments where children nearly covered another's work? How did the rule function as a scaffold?
- What does it feel like to see your contribution as part of something bigger? How did children navigate that?
- How does the 'you cannot cover someone else's work' rule function as a metaphor for democratic cooperation?

EYLF LINKS

This lesson directly supports EYLF Outcome 5 (Communicating) & Outcome 2 (Community). Educators should record observations using anecdotal notes, photographs, or learning stories focused on children's language, body responses, and social interactions during the session.